Research Brief: What Matters in RFQ to Quote

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Status: Approved by Ken, 2026-10-10. Research is running.

Feeds: the product brief: what it puts first, and Q2 (our sharper angle).

Governing question

Section 1

What are the real problems and value props in going from an industrial RFQ to a sent quote, and which matter most to quoting reps and buyers?

And within that: **what part of turning a messy industrial RFQ into a quote hurts quoting reps and buyers the most, and that existing tools do not already solve, so that our demo can win on uniqueness and trust?**

The decisions this supports

Section 2

1. **What the product puts first.** Which problems the demo solves, and which value props it shows the RudCo judges: speed, accuracy, win rate, margin, compliance, or something else.

2. **Our sharper angle.** Ken picks one to build into the demo today. The four candidates in the product brief are:

- **The quote shows its work.** Every field links back to the RFQ words it came from.
- **One-click buyer questions.** Unclear lines go back as choices, not "please clarify."
- **Learns the buyer's shorthand.** A confirmed reading carries over to that buyer's next RFQ.
- **Catches hidden requirements.** Flags certifications the spec implies but the buyer never wrote down.

The research may also surface a better angle than these four. That counts as a result.

Go deep only where depth changes either decision. Record everything else as background.

Why now

Section 3

Hacking ends at 4:30 PM ET today, Saturday, October 10, 2026. Devpost submissions and a video demo are due then. Uniqueness is one of the four judging criteria, each scored out of 5. The angle has to be picked early enough to build.

Research questions

Section 4

0. **The job steps.** What are the steps from receiving an RFQ to sending the quote, who does each step, and where does the time go? What does a faster or better quote win the supplier: more orders, better margin, fewer returns, happier buyers? Which of those value props do suppliers and buyers name themselves?
1. **Pain.** In their own words, what do quoting reps, inside sales, and estimators at metal service centers and industrial distributors say is slowest, most error-prone, or most annoying about quoting from RFQs? What do buyers say is most annoying about receiving quotes?
2. **Messy lines.** What do real RFQ line items look like? Collect real examples of the same item written different ways. These become our demo test cases.

3. **Costly mistakes.** Which reading errors cost the most when they slip through? For example: wrong gauge-to-thickness table, wrong grade, missing certification, wrong unit.
4. **Hidden requirements.** Which certifications and paperwork do buyers expect without asking? Mill test reports, country of origin and domestic-sourcing rules (DFARS, Buy America), and spec certifications. What triggers each one?
5. **Existing tools.** What already automates RFQ intake or quoting for metals and industrial supply? What does each do well, and where do users say it falls short?
6. **Price benchmarks.** Which public price sources for metals (indices, published surcharges) could back a "why this price is competitive" explanation? This overlaps with Yuval's data question (Q1 in the product brief). Report what is public and free, and hand the rest to Yuval.

Research tracks

Section 5

Track	Covers	Who runs it
Voice of user, Reddit	Questions 0 to 4	`reddit-researcher` agent. Ken saves the pages it lists.
Voice of user, open web	Questions 0 to 4: industry forums (Practical Machinist, Eng-Tips), LinkedIn posts, and trade press for service centers and distributors	web research agent
Domain rules	Questions 3 and 4: gauge tables by material, common ASTM specs for sheet, plate, bar and tube, and when mill test reports and origin rules apply	web research agent
Existing tools	Question 5	web research agent
Price benchmarks	Question 6	web research agent

Reddit communities to search: r/sales, r/manufacturing, r/procurement, r/supplychain, r/Machinists, r/metalworking, r/Welding, r/engineering, and any community for industrial distribution or estimators that turns up along the way. Search in the words practitioners use: "RFQ", "quote", "estimating", "inside sales", "service center", "MTR", "certs", "gauge", "takeoff".

Scope

Section 6

In:

- Metals first (sheet, plate, bar, tube, pipe), since the RudCo examples are metals. Abrasives and aggregates only if they come up.
- Public sources: forums, Reddit, trade press, vendor pages, standards bodies' public pages.

Out:

- Paid standards documents and paid price data.
- How to build the agent. That is architecture, not research.

Method

Section 7

- Web research by parallel agents, each writing its own findings file.
- A Reddit loop: the agent lists pages, Ken saves them, the agent reads them, repeat.
- Collect real messy line items into one test-case file the builders can use.

What the report delivers

Section 8

1. **A map of the RFQ-to-quote job**, with the problems at each step and the value props ranked by how much reps and buyers care.

2. **The four angles ranked**, plus any new one found, each with the evidence for it: how much users hurt, whether a tool already does it, and how it shows trust to the judges.
3. **A test set of real messy RFQ lines**, each with the correct reading where the source makes it clear.
4. **A short list of hidden requirements** and what triggers each one.
5. **Public price sources**, handed to Yuval.
6. **Claude's recommendation** on what to put first and which angle to build, with a confidence rating.

Every claim gets a linked source. Quotes from named people link to their own words. The Reddit track's gaps are stated before its findings, not after.